

CHARLES DIBDIN AND THE MAKING OF
THE MUSICAL TOUR OF MR. DIBDIN (1788):
 A NEW “COMPACT WITH THE PUBLIC”

by

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ON 17 March 1787, Charles Dibdin (1745–1814) took the stagecoach from London to Oxford, “with a few shirts and books in a trunk, [and] a well-digested plan in [his] head.”¹ Famous first as an actor-singer, then as a theatre composer who collaborated with such luminaries as David Garrick and Isaac Bickerstaff, then as a writer for the theatre himself, Dibdin was “an extremely well-known public character”² who was now, in the spirit of entrepreneurship increasingly shaping his activities, seeking to integrate his talents. The “well-digested plan” was for a one-man musical show which Dibdin intended touring round the country to fund his family’s planned emigration to India; standing behind a piano (an instrument he had introduced in Britain), he would alternately speak and sing to his audience. By appearing as poet, composer, performer and “band,” Dibdin later wrote, he was doing something “so unprecedented, that one should rationally suppose, if it were only for the novelty, it were likely to attract curiosity, and ensure encouragement.”³ *Readings and Music*, as he called his entertainment, was to prove personally, professionally, even culturally transformative; with it, the second half of Dibdin’s career commenced. In the end, he never did go to India, but he decided that the one-man show, which he began calling a “Table Entertainment,” on the model of “table talk,” was his natural medium, and he went on developing the form. For a time, his shows were sensationally popular, and between 1791 and 1805 Dibdin even had his own London theatre, the Sans Souci, specifically to present them. The songs he produced for these Table Entertainments had an immense impact on the popular song repertoire, making Dibdin overwhelmingly the leading anglophone singer-songwriter of the age. The form of the shows, too, had a huge influence on popular entertainment, almost every subsequent proponent of the one-man show with music owing something, directly or indirectly, to Dibdin. They very

1. Charles Dibdin, *The Musical Tour of Mr. Dibdin* (Sheffield, 1788), 13–14. Subsequent references are noted parenthetically in the text.

2. Oskar Cox Jensen, David Kennerley and Ian Newman (eds.), *Charles Dibdin and Late Georgian Culture* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 1. This volume is the best introduction to the great variety of Dibdin’s achievements and cultural impacts, though it has little to say about him as a writer or solo performer.

3. Charles Dibdin, *The Professional Life of Mr. Dibdin*, 4 vols. (London, 1803), 1:4.

likely also influenced the culture of London's "song-and-supper rooms" which started opening in 1815—the direct ancestors of the later music hall.⁴

The *Readings and Music* tour proved transformative in another way, too: it persuaded Dibdin that he could and should produce books. Although from the early 1770s onwards his literary ambitions were steadily developing, there is no evidence prior to 1787 of a serious interest in book production. He had published librettos, a polemical pamphlet, *The Royal Circus Epitomized* (1784), and his own periodical, *The Devil*, which ran for 22 issues in 1786 and 1787. But after his 1787–88 tour produced the *Musical Tour of Mr. Dibdin*, a 450-page quarto far bigger in size and scope than anything he had written before, he began thinking on a different scale, publishing three three-volume novels between 1793 and 1807, a five-volume *Complete History of the English Stage* between 1797 and 1800, two large volumes of *Observations on a Tour Through Almost the Whole of England, and a Considerable Part of Scotland* in 1801 and 1802, and four volumes of *The Professional Life of Mr. Dibdin* in 1803. The *Musical Tour* directly anticipates, in different ways, most of the major publications that followed. Dibdin discovered a taste for autobiographical writing mixed with anecdotes, opinions and polemics; although he has, at most, appeared as a footnote in accounts of Romantic autobiography, no British writer published more about themselves in the decades between 1780 and 1810.

Despite the great importance of the *Musical Tour* (hereafter *MT*) in Dibdin's polymathic career, it is as flawed as it is fascinating. It did not develop smoothly and Dibdin had written much of it before deciding on the final shape and content of the volume. Moreover, he was often juggling the historical aspects of his account with a desire to comment on his present circumstances. When Dibdin left London, he had no idea of recording his experiences: "at my first setting out I had not the smallest idea of writing any account of my TOUR at all" (43–44). Not until August did he lay plans for a book, and not until October did he begin systematically writing it. Given that the tour itself continued until March 1788, this meant that for a long time Dibdin was having to catch up with himself, and he recognized almost immediately the parallels with Laurence Sterne's 1760s novel, *Tristram Shandy* (10). As the project developed, it came to unite the different worlds of self-publishing, provincial printing, financing by subscription and—belatedly—royal patronage. Scholars have paid some attention to the tour itself, and to *Readings and Music*,⁵ but there has been no separate analysis of the complex vehicle through which Dibdin preserved a record of these things. The published *MT* is the more interesting in that, uniquely among Dibdin's major prose publications, a complete fair copy manuscript of the book has been preserved, held in the Fellows' Library at Winchester College (MS 61). Although there are few significant departures from this bound manuscript volume in the printed text, the

4. For the "song-and-supper rooms" and their place in London's entertainment culture, see Laurence Senelick, introduction to *Tavern Singing in Early Victorian London: The Diaries of Charles Rice for 1840 and 1850* (London: Society for Theatre Research, 1997), xii.

5. See, in particular, Elisabeth M. Lockwood, "Charles Dibdin's Musical Tour," *Music and Letters* 13, no. 2 (1932): 207–14; and Jeremy Barlow, "Dibdin on Tour: Performer or Sight-seer?," *Early Music Performer* 39 (October 2016): 3–8.

manuscript provides fascinating clues to the process by which the book came to be made, and it is regularly cited in the history reconstructed here.⁶

The story of the tour commences on page 15 of the published *MT*; the history of the book about the tour effectively commences on page 91, when Dibdin describes his return to Worcester on 31 July 1787 after an earlier visit in the spring. There follows one of the most ambiguous and conflicted passages in the volume:

I never experienced more *milk and water* treatment in my life. I advertised my entertainment however and was tolerably attended. . . . I sincerely believe, had it not been for the interference of a friend, I must have used the word INTOLERABLY. To this gentleman, who is no other than T. S. Esq. [.] I shall beg leave to say, that if he meant his friendship and attention to my interest should finish where it apparently has—God forbid I should load him with more trouble than he is willing to suffer! So far from it—I here, in the face of the world, acquit him of any intentions in relation to me, but those of serving, obliging, and pleasing me; and should it so happen that neither upon paper, nor any other way, we again exchange a single word, my wishes towards him are, may he enjoy a long life of health, happiness, and prosperity! And I hope he retains so much of his former good wishes for me, as to return an equal portion of esteem, with equal sincerity. (91)

Readers are expected to recall that the first eleven letters of the *MT* had been addressed “To T. S. Esq.” Dibdin later chose to reveal the identity of this individual, for in his *Professional Life* he states: “The name of THEOPHILUS SWIFT, Esq. will be seen at the head of some of the poetry. . . . To this gentleman I addressed a few letters in my original *Tour*.”⁷ Swift (1746–1815), whose parents were both cousins of Jonathan Swift, the author of *Gulliver’s Travels*, was an eccentric Irish barrister. The fullest contemporary description describes him as “an excellent classic [*sic*] scholar, and versed likewise in modern literature and belles lettres. . . . [He was] a sincere, kind-hearted man; but . . . at the same time, the most visionary of created beings. He saw every thing whimsically—many things erroneously—and nothing like another person.”⁸ Swift had just commenced a literary career by publishing a lengthy poem, *The Temple of Folly*. It is not clear when or where he and Dibdin first became connected, but it was sometime prior to this consequential meeting in Worcester, as a cryptic clue inserted into the *MT* indicates. In a letter to Swift of 16 October 1787, Dibdin writes: “You may remember, in a letter written to me some time ago, you wondered at my advertising my entertainment at BIRMINGHAM” (25). Dibdin performed at Birmingham in between his two visits to Worcester. The reference to the earlier letter suggests that Swift was probably not at Worcester when Dibdin first visited, or he would hardly have needed to

6. I am much indebted to Richard Foster, the Fellows’ Librarian, Winchester College, for allowing me access to the manuscript, for his generous hospitality when I visited Winchester, and for the information that the manuscript was donated to the College in the 1830s or 1840s by the Rev. Peter Hall (1803–49), a prolific collector of books and manuscripts and a former Winchester student. The records show that the manuscript was bound when first acquired by the College, though it was subsequently rebound in the twentieth century. The history of the manuscript before Hall acquired it, presumably no earlier than the 1820s, is unknown, but it seems likely that Dibdin’s printer, Joseph Gales, made the original decision to bind together the letters that constitute it.

7. Dibdin, *Professional Life*, 3:7.

8. Sir Jonah Barrington, *Personal Sketches of His Own Times*, 2 vols. (London, 1827), 1:405–6.

write on the subject of the latter's "advertising . . . at BIRMINGHAM." His presence on the second visit may have something to do with it coinciding with "the race week" (56), which in 1787 ended on 7 August.⁹ More importantly, the 16 October letter establishes that Dibdin was on terms of correspondence with Swift before summer 1787.

Worcester, a city with a population of around 11,000 at the time, was a regional shopping centre with substantial gloving and porcelain industries. A theatre had been opened in 1781, but Worcester was not known for its culture. Swift, though mostly resident in Dublin, owned a house there. His father, Deane Swift, died at Worcester in 1783, and the dedication to *The Temple of Folly* is dated "Worcester, April 12th, 1787."¹⁰ It is easy to imagine an eccentric Irishman with strong literary interests being glad to welcome the diversions Dibdin offered. Dibdin stayed in Worcester a full two weeks on his second visit, considerably longer than he usually stayed at one place on his tour; there was thus plenty of time for him and Swift to see each other. It is possible Dibdin had already conceived the idea of publishing an account of his tour in a series of letters; but, even if this were the case, it was the conversations with Swift that prompted him to start work. Given the dates, though, it is more likely that the whimsical, "visionary" Swift came up with the idea of a *Musical Tour*—perhaps in response to Dibdin's lively stories about his experiences—making him, given what I have suggested above, a vital influence on Dibdin's career, though one which has gone entirely unrecognized.

Dibdin directed a first *MT* letter to Swift on 16 August, just two days after leaving Worcester. It can certainly be called "visionary" in the plans it lays out. Dibdin, now in Hereford, promises that, in addition to a basic narrative of his movements and experiences, the planned book will

give the public some useful hints relative to inns, manufactories, natural and artificial curiosities, the state of the country as to cultivation, and such other particulars as have cursorily struck me. . . . Having also had many opportunities of conversing with men of genius, I shall communicate my remarks on those conversations; in which, in particular, will be comprised my sentiments on MUSIC in all its points of view. . . . Another object which peculiarly demands my attention is the THEATRE. Nor will a fair exposition of its arcana come by any means improperly through the medium of this publication. An account of the motives which induce me to quit my native country are a part of my compact with the public, and they cannot be enumerated without relating many theatrical transactions. . . . These matters, together with a prodigious number of observations, both of my own and others, on all general subjects—anecdotes, and the essence of what I have delivered, at different places, under the title of READINGS and MUSIC, will make up a series of letters. (2–4)

Importantly, this first letter shows Dibdin envisaging a much more dialogic work than that which eventually emerged. He describes Swift, remarkably, and with a good deal of flattery, as "the best judge I know of all general subjects, whether natural or acquired" (1). And crucially, in the conclusion, he expresses a hope that the letters "with the advantage of your [Swift's] sentiments on each separate letter, [will] be found to excite and satisfy public curiosity" (4). This suggests that

9. *Baily's Racing Register, from the Earliest Records to the Close of the Year 1842*, 3 vols. (London, 1845), 1:617.

10. *The Temple of Folly* (London, 1787), x.

he imagined a book in which his letters would be interspersed with Swift's replies. Whether there had been any talk of Swift benefitting from this financially is unclear, but he was a rich man, unlike Dibdin, and may have suggested some such scheme both to help his friend and raise his own profile in the world of letters. As well as dispatching letters to Swift, Dibdin began making copies of his letters complete with headings and footnotes that would eventually serve as copy for his printer; these fair copies are preserved in the Winchester volume. In the first letter in the manuscript, Dibdin originally had the subtitle "To Theophilus Swift Esq." but the name was subsequently crossed out and replaced with "T. S. Esq." which is then consistently used in the Winchester volume and in the printed *MT*.

Dibdin clearly expected a reply to this first letter but did not get one. He then waited six weeks before writing to Swift again, this time from York, on 28 September. At this juncture, it is clear, he had abandoned any hope of obtaining regular commentary from his friend, and quickly followed this with three more letters, on 30 September and 4 and 5 October. It is significant, I suggest, that the last of these, detailing Dibdin's experiences in Bath the previous March, is mostly taken up with a story about an Irishman (21–22). The Irishman had promised he would ensure a good audience at the Assembly Rooms if Dibdin could set to music a poem written by a lady he was courting and allow him to claim the music as his own. Dibdin set the song, but the "nefarious" Irishman did not keep his promise. In context, it is hard to avoid the conclusion that the story was pointed at Swift, implicitly accusing him of betrayal. Swift himself may have read it that way, for he now, at last replied. His letter was not published, but Dibdin's brief reply to it, dated 14 October, is included in the *MT*.¹¹ Dibdin could now, at last, write:

I cannot have a stronger stimulative to proceed than your kindness. The praise you are pleased to afford my introductory letter—which cannot, from its nature, be so entertaining as those of which it is the harbinger—gives me very flattering hopes that this testimony of public gratitude will hold some rank in the world's estimation. (5)

Dibdin gave this letter the title "Encouragement to Proceed" and rather misleadingly placed it second in the *MT*, allowing the casual reader the impression that Swift had responded reasonably promptly to the initial letter, though giving the date at the bottom to make clear to the careful reader that this was not the case.

By this time, it must have been obvious to Dibdin that he was not going to get Swift's "sentiments on each separate letter," but he felt encouraged enough to go on, as the Irishman had clearly made some sort of assurance that he would try to do better. Dibdin despatched further letters on the 16, 17, 21 and 22 October, the last with a dramatic postscript which could have come straight from a sentimental novel of the period: "Why have I not heard from you!" (39). The next letter, the following day, similarly states: "'Tis hard you will not write to me" (41). These might be read as rhetorical flourishes, designed to make the published tour more readable, but it appears that frustration lay behind them, and Dibdin now abruptly stopped directing his letters to Swift. His complex, hurt feelings regard-

11. In the Winchester manuscript, interestingly, Dibdin first dated the letter "Nov 14th" before correcting "Nov" to "Oct" (Letter 2). This suggests that it may have been written some time after its putative date, and for artistic purposes more than anything else. (The Winchester manuscript numbers the letters in their headings, rather than by pages or folios.)

ing the latter's "friendship and attention to my interest" were later expressed in his account of his second Worcester visit, quoted above.

The two or three weeks subsequent to the last letter to Swift were the most critical in the history of the *MT*. Dibdin's next letter signals a general redirection by being addressed "To the Public" and emphatically stating "I shall address no more letters to T. S. Esq." (42). Dibdin reports, a little accusingly, that Swift "very lately told a particular friend of mine that my *seven* first letters—I use his own words—"are wonderfully well written" (42). He wants to insist, then, that Swift had received and approved the letters, even though he only answered one. On a more extenuating note, though, he also refers to "chance having thrown this gentleman [Swift] and I such a distance from each other" (42–43)—a probable reference to Swift having returned to Ireland. The biggest question Dibdin faced at this juncture was whether he should replace Swift with some other correspondent. The second letter subsequent to the Swift letters, dated from Hull on 4 November, was initially addressed "To Mr. Boyton" in the Winchester manuscript, but the "oyton" was then crossed out to leave "The Mr. B." which appears in the published *MT*.¹² This was the exceptionally obscure William Boyton, a music teacher, harpsichordist (one of the best in the country, according to Dibdin), and minor composer.¹³ Dibdin clearly had an excellent relationship with Boyton, who is mentioned eight times in the *MT*. The 4 November letter ends on a rather ambiguous note, and it is not clear whether Dibdin intended to make Boyton a regular correspondent or not: "As to the musical taste of BRISTOL, the treatment at inns, and other indispensable [*sic*] matters, I shall mention them when I return; for I will not give you pain by speaking truth of your neighbours" (49).

Immediately after this, the whole concept of the still largely unwritten book was rethought. The next letter, dated 6 November, is addressed *to* Dibdin:

WHEN I had the pleasure of witnessing your performance, I said but the truth when I assured you it would be no trifling satisfaction to me to promote whatever you should consider as your interest. As to your request of addressing your public letters to me, I embrace with great satisfaction an opportunity of receiving an earlier entertainment from them than the rest of your friends. Nobody can be more zealous in your cause. There is, I confess, one consideration that will make me read them with reluctance—every succeeding letter will be one approach nearer to your departure, which you know I never cordially liked—though I own you have conquered every scruple but one. Answer me. What will the people of INDIA say of you, when they see in your book that you make a visit to them, your *forlorn hope*? You see I begin the office of a friend by treating you with freedom. My remarks, however, will not be very troublesome to you. Your career is brilliant, and it were pity to stop it. Adieu. I have read thirteen letters, and be assured I shall make a perusal of the rest supercede every other consideration of business or pleasure—being

Your sincere friend,

And obedient servant. (50)

12. Letter 13.

13. Roger Fiske estimates Boyton's dates as *c.* 1750 to *c.* 1800 in *English Theatre Music in the Eighteenth Century* (London: Oxford University Press, 1973), 651. I suspect he was the "Mr. BOYTON sen." who was given a benefit concert in Bristol in 1816, however: see "Assembly-Rooms, Prince's Street," *Bristol Mirror*, 9 November 1816, 2. Boyton's son Richard, also a teacher of music in Bristol, was active by the 1810s and died in 1846.

Dibdin responded to this in a letter of 9 November, addressed “To the Rev. Mr. —,” and from this juncture on, all his letters are similarly addressed. The timing of the letter from the “Rev. Mr. —” was singularly timely, and the letter itself reads as more akin to an extract from an epistolary novel than a genuine correspondence from a real clergyman. In fact, a careful reading of the Winchester manuscript and the published *MT* makes it clear that the “Rev. Mr. —” is an imaginary correspondent introduced as a literary convenience.

The first and most irrefutable clue is in the manuscript. The letter has several crossings out and corrections, such as “nobody can be ^{more} zealous in the ^{your} cause & nobody wishes you better.”¹⁴ This strongly points to its being Dibdin’s composition, not a transcription of someone else’s letter.

A second clue is in the letter itself: the giveaway detail “I have read thirteen letters,” in other words *all* the letters of the *MT* written to that point. To try and explain this, in the Winchester manuscript Dibdin initially dated the letter from Lincoln, where he had been on 6 November. The implication, then, was that the “Rev. Mr. —” met him there and was shown the growing set of letters that Dibdin was assembling. Yet on the subscription list there is only one reverend listed under Lincoln, a “Rev. Dr. Gordon” who obviously cannot be the man in question. It is impossible to believe that such an ardent supporter of Dibdin would not have been a subscriber, as both Swift (listed under London) and Boyton (listed under Bristol) were. And if the “Rev. Mr. —” was only visiting Lincoln in November, it was an odd time and place for a clergyman to be taking a holiday. Apparently realizing that he had evoked an unlikely scenario, Dibdin crossed out the word “Lincoln,” which does not appear in the published *MT*. But if the “Rev. Mr. —” was not in Lincoln, how could he have read all thirteen letters, the latest written just two days earlier?

A third clue is that the *MT* never refers to Dibdin meeting the “Rev. Mr. —.” This is crucial, for in general Dibdin was keen to name and praise his supporters, and to detail where he met them. He refers to his meeting with Swift, as noted above, possibly suppressing the Irishman’s full name because, by the time he described the meeting, he felt Swift had let him down. Dibdin also refers in more detail to his time with Boyton, and, as noted above, mentions him eight times. Yet we are supposed to think that by 6 November Dibdin had found a very willing friend and supporter who goes wholly unmentioned in the narrative. Moreover, the name of the “Rev. Mr. —” is ostentatiously suppressed. In Dibdin’s first letter to him, he says he will publish the latter’s letter, but:

It shall be printed ... without your name—nor shall I publicly use it [the name] at all, though out of kindness you have stipulated for no such arrangement. My reason is, that though I may find it necessary to go to loggerheads with wittings and crotchet-mongers, it would be unhandsome to bring you in as my second, or even bottle-holder. (51)

The reader, then, is meant to accept that the name is concealed, not because the “Rev. Mr. —” stipulated this, but because Dibdin now wants to protect his correspondent from his, Dibdin’s, quarrels. Dibdin had not chosen to protect Swift and Boyton so carefully.

14. Letter 14.

A fourth and final clue, and the decisive one, is that having introduced the fiction of a "New Correspondent," Dibdin does remarkably little with it. After the initial letter of 6 November, there are no more letters from the "Rev. Mr. —" until 17 February. This represents him as now thoroughly persuaded that Dibdin should go to India, and makes a particular dig at Nottingham, where Dibdin had experienced an unfavourable reception: "The nasty *Snottinghamites* alone would have sickened me to such a degree, that when I appeared before them, it would have given me all the qualmsiness and have produced all the effect of an emetic" (132). Nine days later, Dibdin wrote to acknowledge another communication from the "Rev. Mr. —" which this time had enclosed a satirical "impromptu," "*On hearing of Mr. DIBDIN's ill success at NOTTINGHAM*" (152).¹⁵ The reader, then, is left to conclude that of all the strong views Dibdin expresses on people, places and issues in the course of the *MT*, the only one which really exercised the feelings and pen of the "Rev. Mr. —" were the remarks on Nottingham! If this was meant to hint that the "Rev. Mr. —" might be a disgruntled member of the Nottingham clergy, or perhaps based in Derby, Nottingham's great regional rival, it was a red herring: no "Rev. Mr." appears on the subscribers' lists for these towns. In general, Dibdin went on writing letter after letter to the "Rev. Mr. —" without any stated expectation of a reply or frustration at the lack of one.

Altogether, then, the evidence is overwhelmingly against the "Rev. Mr. —" being a real person, suggesting that Dibdin significantly rethought the nature of his book in early November 1787. The advantages were obvious: he would no longer need to make duplicate copies of his letters, would no longer need to wait for replies that might never come, and could, when in the mood, write his own replies. Nevertheless, it is possible that Dibdin hoped his readers would link the "Rev. Mr. —" address of the letters to an actual person. Of the 25 people with that designation in the subscribers' lists, one was a major literary figure, with several interests coincident with Dibdin's: William Mason (1725–97), the rector of Aston. He had subscribed in Sheffield, which is presumably where he saw Dibdin's entertainment, and Dibdin had been there in October 1787. Dibdin may have hoped that curious readers would make the link with Mason, and the signature "*****" suggested a name of five characters. Dibdin was often less than polite when assessing the merits of his contemporaries, but he would later describe Mason as "a sweet and beautiful writer, and a man universally beloved and esteemed."¹⁶

The removal of Swift from Dibdin's publishing plan appears to have significantly impacted the planned book in another way, too. Dibdin's letter "To the Public" of 24 October—the one in which he states "I shall address no more letters to T. S. Esq."—also contains this information:

15. Interestingly, in the following decade George Moutard Woodward quoted a slightly different version of the "impromptu" with the statement that it was "said to be written by the celebrated Mr. Dibden [*sic*] (from woeful experience) and supposed to be addressed to himself." See his *Eccentric Excursions: Or, Literary & Pictorial Sketches* (London, 1796), 178.

16. Charles Dibdin, *A Complete History of the English Stage*, 5 vols. (London, 1797–1800), 5:289.

Five minutes before I sat down to this table where I am now writing, being at BEVERLY in Yorkshire, I dispatched to the printer at HULL a manuscript of the *proposal* for publishing my MUSICAL TOUR. (45)

Hull was just nine miles by road from Beverly, and the printing was clearly done quickly, so when Dibdin later came to his account of these days he could state "At BEVERLY I first issued my proposals for printing this work" (139). Dibdin had now decided to make the *MT* a subscription volume and realized his tour offered him a wonderful opportunity for collecting subscribers. It may be just a coincidence that he took his first steps toward this just after breaking with Swift, but the evidence suggests it was part of his larger rethinking of the book at this time. Swift had recently published *The Temple of Folly* with the well-known London publisher Joseph Johnson, and may have believed that he had the influence, and perhaps the money, to ensure the acceptance of a completed manuscript volume by an established publisher. Dibdin now concluded, probably correctly, that he stood to make rather more money if he became his own publisher and used his performances as a way of advertising for subscriptions. In the future, he would regularly be his own publisher.

Dibdin provided a good deal of business for printers in the course of his tour. On arriving in a new area, he would employ the local printer to produce handbills advertising his performances. We even know how much he expected to pay for these, for on his second visit to Derby he complained that the printer John Drewry wanted "to charge half-a-crown [i.e., 30p] a hundred for the same sort of bills which he had printed the first time I was there for eighteen-pence" (153–54). From November 1787 onwards, these handbills probably routinely mentioned the planned subscription volume, and for anyone wanting to know more, Dibdin had his separate "proposal." Working with Dibdin in this way, it would not be surprising if regional printers showed an interest in printing the *MT* itself, and Dibdin assures his readers that this was the case: "Before I ever saw Mr. GALES I had received numberless civilities at the hands of different *printers*, from many of whom I have had offers to print my TOUR—after I knew Mr. GALES, I preferred him to all the printers I had seen" (207). Joseph Gales (1761–1841), remembered most of all for his radical views and later career in America, was a young printer who had set up business in Sheffield in 1784. Dibdin's first visit to Sheffield took place in mid-October 1787, and lasted two or three days (129). He makes no mention of having met Gales on that occasion, but he probably did so, for at the end of the year he received a letter from the printer, seemingly inviting him to return to Sheffield, which he promptly did, arriving on 31 December. Because of this return, Dibdin later wrote, he "acquired the friendship of Mr. GALES, and the satisfaction of employing him to print this work" (208).

Dibdin remained in Sheffield until 12 January 1788 (213) and in this period must have made definite plans with Gales for the printing of the volume, contracting for 600 copies (Advertisement). Dibdin then took off to Manchester for ten days or so before returning to Sheffield; "on the following week," he then writes, "this TOUR was put to press" (242). Although Dibdin does not specify the date, these clues suggest that Gales and his apprentices probably started work on Dibdin's incomplete manuscript on Monday 28 January. Dibdin was able to

inspect 64 pages (four sheets) of proofs before leaving Sheffield again, this time for Leeds, where he performed on 11 February. Dibdin later wrote that "it was utterly impracticable I should myself superintend more than the first sixty-four pages" (435). A comparison of the Winchester manuscript with the published *MT* shows that he made several corrections at this stage. He must also have approved Gales' typography and generous page layout: there is no doubt that the intention was to produce a large, impressive volume. From this time on, he would send Gales regular instalments of the work through the post: "more than three-fourths of the copy has gone, letter after letter by the post," Dibdin noted as he approached the end of his book (436). Although he seems to imply here that the letters were sent individually to Gales, it is hard to believe that he would not have sometimes bundled several together. The Winchester manuscript supports this, a certain number of pages containing Gales' address and post stamps but the number of these far less than the number of letters.

Dibdin's position in late January 1788 was almost comically desperate. He had written less than a quarter of the final *MT* and brought his story up to around the end of August 1787. When he commenced serious work on the *MT* in October, he had around six months with which to catch up. Now, in January, he was still nearly five months behind himself. Yet his stated intention was to sail for India in April, by which time the *MT* needed to be completed, published, and delivered to subscribers. The only realistic solution was to accept that the *MT* would not be able to cover the entirety of the still ongoing tour. Dibdin did so, and on 17 February wrote to Gales from Newcastle, asking him to advertise that "The subscription will finally close by the fifteenth of March and the publication be out by the twenty fifth."¹⁷ The same day he wrote a second letter to himself from the imaginary "Rev. Mr. —", this time commencing with the dramatic injunction:

Go to INDIA—dig in mines—tempt any danger—do any thing to better your fortune—to place yourself beyond the power of such humiliation! I declare to heaven I could not *sustain* the mortifications that you have *smiled* at, let what might be the consideration. (132)

Two days later Dibdin replied to this in a manner that suggests he believed he was concluding the *MT*. This letter of 19 February is entitled "The Duty of a Public Man" and it sets out a general account of Dibdin's "public conduct" before swelling to a magniloquent conclusion unlike anything he had written before:

I believe the best command and obedience within the exercise of the human mind, is a peremptory subduction of all feelings but those which tend to the expansion of the heart, and promote the wide and benevolent circulation of universal liberality, and an implicit submission to all those moral duties which soften the manners, humanize the soul, and impel us to beneficent acts of general fraternal kindness that can alone *dignify reason*, and lift us into MANLY PREMINENCE. (138)

Had the book concluded here, it would have been less than a third of its eventual length and detailed the tour up to the beginning of November 1787.

17. This letter is preserved in the Winchester manuscript of the *MT*, between letters 31 and 32.

But Dibdin almost immediately changed his mind. The next letter is dated the following day, 20 February, though there must be some suspicion that Dibdin backdated this in an attempt to disguise the sense of a grand terminus. The really consequential decision behind this was the determination to delay the move to India, thus allowing the tour to be extended and the publication date of the *MT* to be significantly postponed. He later obliquely explained the change of plan in a letter of 28 April 1788: "I found, should I do so [sail for India in April], I must have gone abroad in a more unpleasant way than—I thank my *able and willing* friends—I am now likely to do" (423). The reference seems to be primarily to the fact that, by extending the tour, he realized he could make a good deal more money. But the delay also allowed him to finish his book to his satisfaction, and to turn it into a monumental farewell to England. In the end he would not set out on his abortive journey until August.

Between 20 February and 4 March, Dibdin composed ten further letters, adopting a more summary style of narration that took advantage of the fact he had visited many places more than once. This allowed him to bring his account up to mid-December, meaning he was now only three and half months behind himself. Had Dibdin continued at this rate, he could probably have caught up with his own movements in five or six weeks. But he was now returning to Liverpool, a city which had proved particularly welcoming and supportive, and he could potentially make a lot of money there. Dibdin accordingly found himself in a dilemma: should he concentrate on his performances, and all the social networking that ensured good attendance at those performances, or should he concentrate on the *MT*? The solution he adopted is explained in the penultimate letter in the *MT*:

When I went last from SHEFFIELD to LIVERPOOL, the matter then written went no farther than Letter 44—which the reader will see is dated SHEFFIELD, March 4. As I well knew the hospitality I should find at LIVERPOOL, on my return, and the variety of pleasures that would be kindly chalked out for me, I felt myself conscious that to keep pace with Mr. GALES would be no easy matter. We therefore agreed that as soon as Letter 44 should be finished, to go on upon Letter 75, which begins *The Readings*; as, instead of *inventing*, I should in that case have nothing to do but *copy*. Thus we calculated that there would be a vacancy of thirty letters—a number sufficient to contain all that it would be necessary to say on the TOUR itself, and the statement of pieces. We outreckoned ourselves however two ways. In the first place, in bringing up the matter to page 307, instead of 305 or 309, we found ourselves entangled with an odd quarter of a sheet, and were thus obliged to have duplicates of the *pages* 307 and 308, though the *matter* will be found different. This will all be clearly understood by noticing that Letter 44, is dated as above SHEFFIELD, March 4, Letter 75—which begins *The Readings*—is dated LIVERPOOL, March 6, Letter 98—which finishes *The Readings*—is dated LONDON, March 22, and Letter 45—which returns again to the main subject, is dated LONDON, March 25. (438)

There is much to think about in this fascinating glimpse behind the scenes. Dibdin's report makes it clear that, unsurprisingly, he wanted to publish the finished *Tour* as soon as possible after completing it; and that by March 1788 he had decided that the completed book should contain the full text of *Readings and Music*. His initial plan, as set out in the first letter, it may be recalled, involved "the essence of what I have delivered, at different places, under the title of READINGS and MUSIC." It seems unlikely that he meant by that the complete, extended text of his entertainment. But what is most remarkable about the early March

plans is their grandiosity. On 4 March, Dibdin had brought his narration up to mid-December, and his book up to 183 pages. So far, then, he had worked at a rate of approximately twenty pages per month of tour. By now allowing 123 pages for the rest of the tour, he was apparently thinking it might continue to June, or, alternatively, planning a great deal more digression.

Dibdin's later working practice with his "Table Entertainments" was to write out the text he intended to perform, but then to make numerous additions, deletions and rearrangements as he continued to refine and adapt his work.¹⁸ Assuming that *Readings and Music* existed in some comparable form, Dibdin's job in Liverpool was indeed to "copy," but also to tidy and regulate. Although the epistolary format made little sense when it came to presenting a supposedly continuous dramatic text, he continued to employ it. *Readings and Music* is thus divided into no less than 24 letters, each one commencing on a new page: the headings, each occupying a third of the page, the spaces at the ends of the letters, and some added footnotes, extend the text to a remarkable 100 pages, not counting the unnumbered pages of score expanding it still further. Even the casual reader can be in no doubt that Dibdin is seeking to fill as many pages as possible. What he presents is not equivalent to any single performance of the show, but a sort of aggregate of all the versions through which it had evolved. Thus the published version in the *MT* includes 50 songs, though Dibdin's normal performance practice was to sing 24. As he notes in the passage quoted above, Dibdin prepared a text of this "ideal," extended version of the show between 6 and 22 March.

After a brief rest, on 25 March Dibdin began work on the 123-page missing section he would require to complete his volume, and that in the end needed to be 125 pages long. What Dibdin and Gales had forgotten is that the nature of the printing process meant the total number of pages prior to the new material (i.e., *Readings and Music*) needed to be divisible by four—to avoid a single leaf having to be inserted—which would have been the case had they started printing *Readings and Music* on page 305 or 309.¹⁹ Dibdin did not find it as easy to fill the gap as he apparently expected. His account of the tour proper was completed on 17 April, but this only brought him to page 249, leaving another 59 pages of additional content urgently needing to be filled. Here Dibdin announces that he will "wind up" with a "running account of places, inns, &c. and a few more gleanings," as well as more "remarks on the subject of music" and a catalogue "of my [theatrical] pieces, and the profits which arose from them" (249). It was the catalogue that served Dibdin best, for, rather absurdly divided into letters like everything else, it filled 24 pages. His original plans for the *MT* had mentioned "many theatrical transactions," but it is hard to believe that he then imagined it encompassing this sort of career overview. Given that a persistent theme of the book is Dibdin's not being properly appreciated in England—hence the intended

18. There are three manuscript volumes of Dibdin's performance texts for the "Table Entertainments" in the British Library (Add. Mss. 30,960–30,962). From these, notably, *Retro-spect Opera* has recently been able to create a performance edition and recording of *The Wags* (1790), Dibdin's biggest success in the genre (RO008).

19. Strictly speaking, I believe Dibdin was wrong to say they were "entangled with an odd quarter of a sheet": they were "entangled" with an odd eighth of a sheet, i.e., 2 pages.

removal to India—the catalogue allowed him to settle a few more scores and it is not too obviously out of place in what was already a very heterogeneous volume. To modern Dibdin scholars, it has proved invaluable. Dibdin completed the catalogue on 25 April, at which point he had just over 400 consecutive pages of the *MT* completed.

Dibdin was still not done. The following day he headed a new letter “The Corps de Reserve” and claimed to have “purposely reserved about forty pages for general observations” (407). These were mostly concerned with newspapers and the culture of reviewing and criticism—themes which had earlier loomed large in *The Devil*. Dibdin was, among his many other talents, a notable amateur artist who was able to exhibit at the Royal Academy in 1801, and he drew on the vocabulary of painting to justify this final section of the book: he would “rub off hardinesses, and throw in some finishing touches, to make this picture have a proper roundness and harmony in its general effects” (422). It was an awkward metaphor given that he could not change what had already been printed, and it is unlikely that any reader has ever found the book particularly harmonious: nevertheless, it is significant that Dibdin wanted his work judged this way. He dated the last letter—Letter 107—on 1 May, the day he initially closed the subscription, and the volume was finally complete. Toward the end of his labours, Dibdin claimed that the *MT* had been “written in a greater hurry than ever book was” (419). Even allowing for his proclivity to exaggeration, he surely cannot have considered this the case prior to March 1788. But nearly two-thirds of the volume had been written in March and April, and though hardly unprecedented, this was certainly impressive, especially as there is no obvious falling off in the quality of Dibdin’s writing in these months.

In this final period of intense work, Dibdin enjoyed a remarkable piece of luck which seemingly did a good deal to ensure the success of the *MT*. In a letter dated 23 April, and significantly entitled “The Coup de Theatre,” Dibdin explains that his “kindest and most generous friend” had arranged an audience for him with the Prince of Wales, the future George IV (282). This audience can be dated 5 April 1788 with some precision.²⁰ Dibdin played some twenty songs for the prince, some of them certainly drawn from *Readings and Music*, and the climax of the evening came when the future king said “I might use his name in any way that I thought would be of service to me” (283). Dibdin was thus able to dedicate—or, in his preferred term, “inscribe”—the book to the prince, “With pride of heart, humble deference, and grateful susceptibility.” The Winchester manuscript gives some idea of whom the book might have been dedicated to, had this meeting with the prince not been arranged. It contains four dedications each designed for a “single book”: to Dibdin’s wife; to William Davis (eventually the dedicatee of Dibdin’s *Collection of Songs, Selected from the Works of Mr. Dibdin* of 1790); to Thomas Preston; and to Gales. The most interesting of these is the inscription to “Mrs. Dibdin / in return for the cheerfulness and kind attention

20. Dibdin says that it was the evening when “MARCHESI . . . made his first appearance at the *Opera*” (283). Luigi Marchesi was one of the most celebrated singers of his time and his London debut was seen as a major cultural event.

with which she alleviated the fatigues and inconveniences of / This Tour." She goes entirely unmentioned in the *MT* itself.

The Prince of Wales's patronage gave a late boost to the subscription and Dibdin seems to have been quite overwhelmed by it. Indeed, the royalist sentiments in the *MT* represent another aspect of this remarkable book's transformative significance in his career, for Dibdin had previously felt very differently about the House of Hanover. The major royal event during the period he published *The Devil* was the death of Princess Amelia, George III's aunt and the last surviving child of George II, on 31 October 1786. *The Devil* includes a complaint that "THE papers, and indeed the whole town [are] at this time absurdly full of the death of the Princess Amelia," and offers, as an antidote, a humorous "Impromptu":

AMELIA in the ground doth lie,
And black of course is worn in common;
Hard that so many men must dye!
In compliment to one old woman.²¹

This was probably, though not certainly, written by Dibdin, who in either case was happy to print it, as his only comment on the Princess's death. After the *MT*, such sentiments disappear from his writing, and on the contrary he went out of his way to celebrate royal events, as for example with his *Ode in Honour of the Nuptials of Their Royal Highnesses the Prince and Princess of Wales* (1795). In the wake of the French Revolution, Dibdin's popular brand of royalism, diffused through dozens of songs, did much to shore up loyalist feeling in England.

The publication of the *MT* was set for 12 May. On 26 April, Dibdin and Gales claimed they had "nearly five Hundred" subscribers, some of whom had subscribed for multiple copies, and that the subscription would close on 1 May.²² By the time Gales printed the list of "Subscribers' Names," 557 copies were accounted for, though my own amended copy of the *MT*, seemingly used by Gales as a sort of reference copy, shows that a few subscribers had withdrawn, or been wrongly recorded in the first place. Dibdin intended to take the remaining copies to India. When the volume appeared on 12 May, an "Advertisement" at the front written by Dibdin—occupying the final leaves of the Winchester manuscript—claimed there had been a late surge of interest, with "nearly two hundred" extra copies subscribed for; Dibdin was accordingly extending the subscription to 12 June, after which a "second edition" would be printed by John Preston in London (Gales having "a prior engagement"). This may in part have been marketing hype, for I have found no evidence that any second edition was actually produced. A balanced reading of the evidence would suggest that the book was probably oversubscribed, but not to such an extent that it made sense to print a new edition. Nevertheless, despite his tendency to grumble, it seems that both the musical tour and the volume he wrote about it succeeded beyond Dibdin's expectations.

21. *The Devil* (London, 1786–87), 128 (No. VIII).

22. "Musical Tour," *Sheffield Register*, 26 April 1788, [2].

The consequences were momentous. Having worked the idea of India out of his system, the *MT* became a beginning rather than an end: Dibdin made a decision to stay in England, to entertain the public with “Table Entertainments,” and to go on writing books. His nephew, notably, was Thomas Frognall Dibdin (1776–1847), the celebrated bibliographer, whose early literary interests were very likely stimulated by his uncle’s increasingly serious commitment to the printed word.

